

ἡ Κλεοπάτρα ἡ Χημικός

Cleopatra the Alchemist on Weights and Measures

eul_aid: ses

Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία [Late Antique](#)
Dialect: Κοινή τεχνική [Technical Koine](#)
Domain: Ἐπιστήμη [Science](#)
Format: Πραγματεία [Treatise](#)

Cleopatra the Alchemist is a figure from the late antique period, likely active between the third and fourth century CE. Her historical existence is uncertain, and scholars believe the name is probably a pseudonym. It may have been used to give authority to alchemical writings by associating them with the famous Cleopatra VII of Egypt or with a tradition of learned women. She is considered part of the Greco-Egyptian alchemical tradition centered in Alexandria.

Her primary surviving work is the Chrysopoeia of Cleopatra, a short treatise focused on the transmutation of metals. This work is preserved in later medieval manuscripts of Greek alchemical texts. It is most famous for containing one of the earliest known drawings of an ouroboros—a serpent eating its own tail—accompanied by the motto "The All is One." The treatise also includes diagrams of alchemical equipment like stills and discusses practical laboratory processes.

Cleopatra the Alchemist is significant as one of the few named female authorities in early alchemy. According to modern scholars, her attributed work represents an important blend of practical technique and mystical philosophy. The symbols from the Chrysopoeia, especially the ouroboros and its motto, became central to later alchemical and hermetic thought, representing concepts of unity, eternity, and the cyclical nature of transformation.

Works (1)

- [Περὶ Μέτρων καὶ Σταθμῶν · On Weights and Measures](#) · 28 passages